



Fig. 2: BMW Group uses augmented reality in prototyping (Courtesy: BMW Group)

Universities such as the University of Nevada at Las Vegas and the University of Miami are experimenting with immersive learning experiences. The University of Miami's XR Initiative spans subjects like architecture, healthcare, climate change and behavioural research. Medical students, for example, can learn how to administer anaesthesia to a virtual patient in a simulated operating room.

Invact Metaversity, founded by former Twitter India head Manish Maheshwari and former Microsoft engineer Tanay Pratap, is a full virtual reality university campus replete with a library, cafeteria, hallways, and a playground. It currently offers a 16-week management course, which students can attend from anywhere using a VR headset. It can bring together students and teachers from around the world. The company claims that students can also enjoy the social nuances of college life in the virtual world.

Upskilling: See you at the top!

According to a PwC report, VR is already known to be effective for teaching hard skills and for job skills simulations, such as a flight simulator to train pilots. However, a survey

done by them during the pandemic times showed that VR was, surprisingly, very helpful in soft skills training too! The survey showed that VR can help business leaders upskill their employees faster, even at a time when training budgets may be shrinking and in-person training may be off the table, as people continue to observe social distancing. Learners trained with VR were up to 275% more confident to act on what they learned after training—a 40% improvement over in-person classroom learning and a 35% improvement over eLearning. It showed that employees could also be trained up to four times faster than in a classroom. No wonder then that companies are also turning to the metaverse to train and upskill employees.

Recently, Accenture announced that its 150,000 new hires this fiscal year will use VR headsets to work from the metaverse on their first day. They will meet, collaborate, and learn on the Nth Floor, the company's virtual campus on the metaverse. Accenture believes this immersive experience is 30-40% more productive than traditional ways of learning.

Earlier this year, Mumbai based XR hardware and software company

AjnaLens joined hands with Tata Technologies to digitise 150 industrial training institutes (ITIs) in Karnataka. The ITIs will be equipped with AjnaXR stations to provide immersive skill training. The made-in-India, highly-scalable VR training simulator virtually teleports a trainee to an actual jobsite and provides multi-lingual training. AjnaLens has developed extremely lightweight VR glasses—the AjnaX Glasses—which weigh just around 150gm compared to the average 500gm that popular international brands weigh. This makes it possible for trainees to comfortably wear the glasses and train for long durations. This initiative by the Karnataka government aims to upskill more than 9000 students this year. AjnaLens also provides end-to-end enterprise VR solutions, digital twin solutions, and indigenous defence solutions.

Collaboration and productivity: Work smarter

Companies are betting big on the metaverse to help employees collaborate better, unmindful of geographical distances. Microsoft Mesh, Workplace from Meta (earlier Facebook), Gather, Teamflow, and Virbela are some of the key players in this space. Instead of video-calling colleagues and collaborating using ineffective tools like screen-sharing, the metaverse will enable your *avatars* to gather in a virtual meeting room and collaborate. In fact, you can probably do things more smartly than in a physical office, because the virtual space would enable you to pull holographic images out of your hat, to explain things or make changes to a prototype!

The metaverse is especially handy in a factory environment, where technicians are using both hands and cannot simultaneously use the laptop. Imagine a mechanic working on something complex. What if he had a headset like Microsoft's HoloLens to access the sche-